



Above Freshly made ribbon pasta with shavings of black truffle and slices of ceps, or *funghi porcini*, which also grow in the Umbrian valleys

Left The enchanting village of Castelluccio di Norcia is famous for its lentils, traditionally cooked in Italy as part of New Year's Eve celebrations



Above Truffle hunting in the valleys here is a painstaking business, using specially trained dogs to sniff out the precious truffles



The Best Places to Eat Truffles

La Locanda di Cacio Re moderate

The delights begin even before you reach the doors of this well-reputed restaurant, as the Locanda is set in the beautiful medieval village of Vallo di Nera, still ringed by old stone walls. The restaurant itself is a refurbished 16th-century farmhouse; in summertime, guests can relax over their meal on a spacious terrace overlooking the wild wooded valleys, and there's a light-filled dining room for cooler weather. Three wonderful varieties of truffle are served – the black summer truffle, the winter “special black,” and the white. Chef Paolo Brunelli has put together a choice of four-course menus, one entirely devoted to the truffle. As well as being shaved over fresh *tagliolini* pasta, it accompanies smoked beef carpaccio, stars in truffled lamb, and flavors local cheeses such as *caciotta*. The signature dish is *stringozzi* pasta with sage, *guanciale* cured pork, and flakes of pecorino sheep cheese. Cooking courses, local products, and guest rooms are also offered.

I Casali di Vallo di Nera, Vallo di Nera;
open for lunch and dinner Tue–Sun;
www.caciore.com/locanda

Also in Umbria

The **Taverna Castelluccio** in Castelluccio di Norcia (www.tavernacastelluccio.it; **moderate**) is a wonderful institution, run by a welcoming host who is an expert on all matters local. As well as classics such as *tagliolini al tartufo nero di Norcia* (tagliatelle with Norcia black truffles), he serves *violatri* – wild spinach and hearty sausage stewed with organic lentils grown on the plain below the taverna.

Also in Italy

In a lovingly renovated Piedmont farmhouse in Madonna di Como, Alba, **Locanda del Pilone** (www.locandadelpilone.com; **expensive**) is a superb place to savor the white Alba truffles, as well as other Piedmont specialties. Desserts such as *millefoglie* with cocoa, chestnuts, and vanilla sauce are superb.

Around the World

In California's Bay Area, **Poggio** in Sausalito (www.poggiotrattoria.com **moderate**) regularly gets rave reviews. The menu changes on a daily basis, but throughout the fall, diners are guaranteed delicate white truffles imported from Alba, which on request are shaved over pasta dishes such as gnocchi fashioned from Yukon Gold potatoes smothered with ultra-creamy Valle d'Aosta fondue. Organic vegetables are grown on site and the mozzarella is made in-house.

What Else to Eat

Norcineria roughly translates as “pork sausages.” These are a serious business in Norcia, as testified by the abundance of shops crammed with rows of weird and wonderfully shaped dried and cured **salamis** tied up in string bundles. The *cremoso* variety is soft and perfect for spreading on bread for your picnic lunch, while the richer *cinghiale*, made with wild boar, is more often used in cooked dishes. The tiny, sweet, nutty **lentils** from the vast grassed plain that surrounds Castelluccio di Norcia are famous throughout Italy. At other times of year, sheep graze there, and their milk is lovingly transformed into the tangy and instantly recognizable **pecorino cheese**.